

I spent Rs 5 five lakh. When there was no money left, I gave up dialysis," he says. In April 2023, Balram heard about a free dialysis centre in Barhalganj area of Gorakhpur district in Uttar Pradesh through a relative. For the past seven months, he has been undergoing free dialysis at the Babu R.N. Singh Dialysis Centre in Bharauli village on the banks of Saryu river, 75 km from Gorakhpur town. The centre was inaugurated by Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath on March 29, 2023. Since then, over 5,000 dialysis procedures have been done gratis for 2,000 beneficiaries. Over half of them are from states beyond UP.

This unique organisation is built in the memory of Ram Niwas Singh (1948-2022), a resident of Bharauli. Born in a farmer's family, Ram Niwas moved to Bombay in 1968 and after working as a factory labourer, established the Bombay Intelligence Security (BIS) India Ltd in 1976 which, over the years, grew to become a top security agency of Mumbai. In the '90s, BIS expanded to over a dozen states and now employs over 60,000 employees. In 2003, Ram Niwas fell victim to serious kidney disease. His son Santosh Singh says, "Father used to go through a lot of pain during dialysis. He then thought about the pain caused by dialysis and kidney treatment for the poor living in villages." On his birthday on January 1 in 2022, Ram Niwas announced the construction of a free dialysis centre for the poor. He died in Mumbai the next day. Santosh took over the responsibility of fulfilling his father's dream—gradually shaping a modern dialysis centre on 20,000 square feet of ancestral land in Bharauli. After completing all formalities, a 10-bed dialysis centre was registered with the health department. Says R.B. Aggarwal, former additional director of the UP health department, "Many districts of UP do not have dialysis facilities. In such a situation, the establishment of a dialysis centre in a backward village of Gorakhpur is a unique example of social service."

Fully air-conditioned and with 24-hour power backup, Babu R.N. Singh Dialysis Centre has oxygen facility on every bed. The hospital has a team of three doctors and 15 paramedical staff under the supervision of a specialist with a DM (Nephrologist) degree. Manoj Kumar Singh, local in-charge of the centre, says, "The dialysis of patients is done in the centre in two shifts a day. In this way, a total of 20 patients undergo dialysis in a day." Of course, no fee is charged from patients—only a token charge of Re 1 is charged for registration. There are no criteria for eligibility, and the centre follows a 'first come, first served' policy. Since it is located in interior Gorakhpur, over 90 per cent of the patients are underprivileged. When old patients come for dialysis, appointment is given on priority.

The entire expenditure of the centre is being borne by the corporate social responsibility fund of BIS. "We do not take donations from anyone. The patient and his accompanying attendant also get free breakfast," says Manoj Kumar Singh. An ambulance is also kept ready. Once the patient reaches Gorakhpur, the ambulance fetches him to the centre. Village Bharauli of Gorakhpur is proving to be a pilgrimage site for kidney patients. ■

HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

- **Completely free dialysis for the rural poor of UP and other states**
- **At the rate of 20 patients undergoing dialysis daily, over 2,000 people have undergone 5,000 dialysis sessions till November 2023**
- **Patients treated on a 'first come, first served' basis; free ambulance service offered**

The dialysis centre was conceived by R.N. Singh, founder of Bombay Intelligence Security, who suffered from kidney disease